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Creating the Buddy System: Networking Program for Large Collaboration Meetings



Institute for Artificial Intelligence
& Fundamental Interactions

Goals

Create 1:1 networking
matches to target
collaboration members who...

- are **new**
- are attending **virtually**
- want to make **new connections**

NOT Mentoring:

Requires more structure, more meetings,
mentor training, & careful matching

Yes Networking:

Participants choose how to prioritize matches
& schedule their own, single meetup (we
encourage 1st coffee break)

Gathering Data to Make Matches:



- ☐ Virtual
☐ In-person



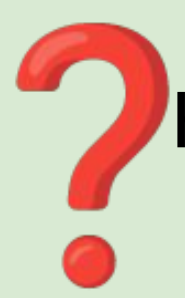
What best describes how long have you been on DUNE?

- ☐ < 6 months
☐ < 1 years
☐ 1-2 years
☐ > 3 years
☐ > 6 years

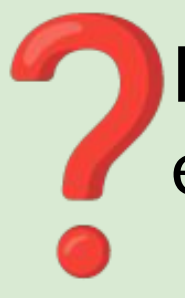


What best describes your job title?

Choose



Hobbies



Research area specific to
experiment



Primary institutions and current workplace (if they differ)
Example: Michigan State University but located at Fermilab

Your answer



Do you want to match with Early Career (EC) Member? Note: Asked
of both EC & non-EC participants!



Any particular preference for matches? (i.e. another new DUNE person, LGBTQ+,
someone at national lab, etc). If you chose "shared identity" above, what shared
identity are you looking for? We will do our best to accommodate when possible.

Your answer

Choose Your Own Adventure

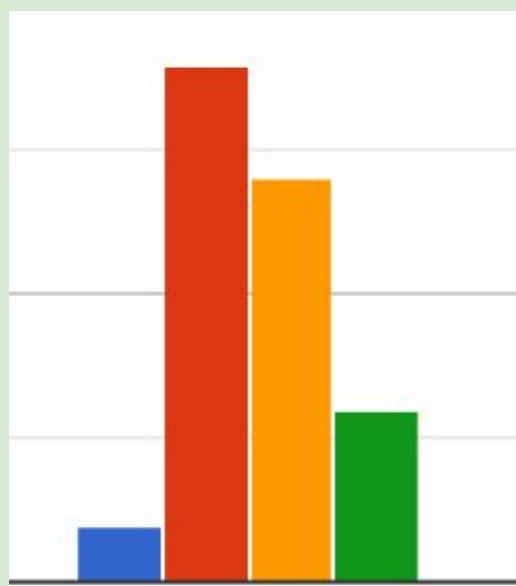


What would you like to discuss with your buddy?
You can make specific requests in following question

	Do not want to talk about	Could talk about	Want to talk about	High priority to talk about
Same research/physics focus	☐	☐	☐	☐
Different research/physics focus	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hobbies/other interests	☐	☐	☐	☐
Shared identity (marginalized person in STEM, from a unique background/location/etc. – please SHARE SPECIFICS below)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Outreach	☐	☐	☐	☐
Diversity, equity, inclusion initiatives	☐	☐	☐	☐
Current USA situation in science (funding prospects, policies, etc.)	☐	☐	☐	☐

Example of Priorities:

- ☒ Do not want to talk about
☒ Could talk about
☒ Want to talk about
☒ High priority to talk about



Current USA
situation

Preferences for Match

Matching

Process:

- Split Virtual & In-Person
- Match special requests first and/or small
categories
→ E.g. If only a few not EC in the virtual,
try to find those who request them
- Focus on strong matching preferences
→ Blue & green in priorities plot

Ask additional people to
take on a buddy if they
match specific request

Groups of 3
or second
"unofficial" match

Creating Community:

Three-time Participant: "This was a
really fun way to get to know people
in a large collaboration!"

Six-time Participant: "It's not always easy to muster the courage to
approach more senior colleagues or even peers in the collaboration.
The Buddy System has made it much easier to connect with and learn
from people I might otherwise never have the chance to talk to."



Jessie Micallef 9:47 PM

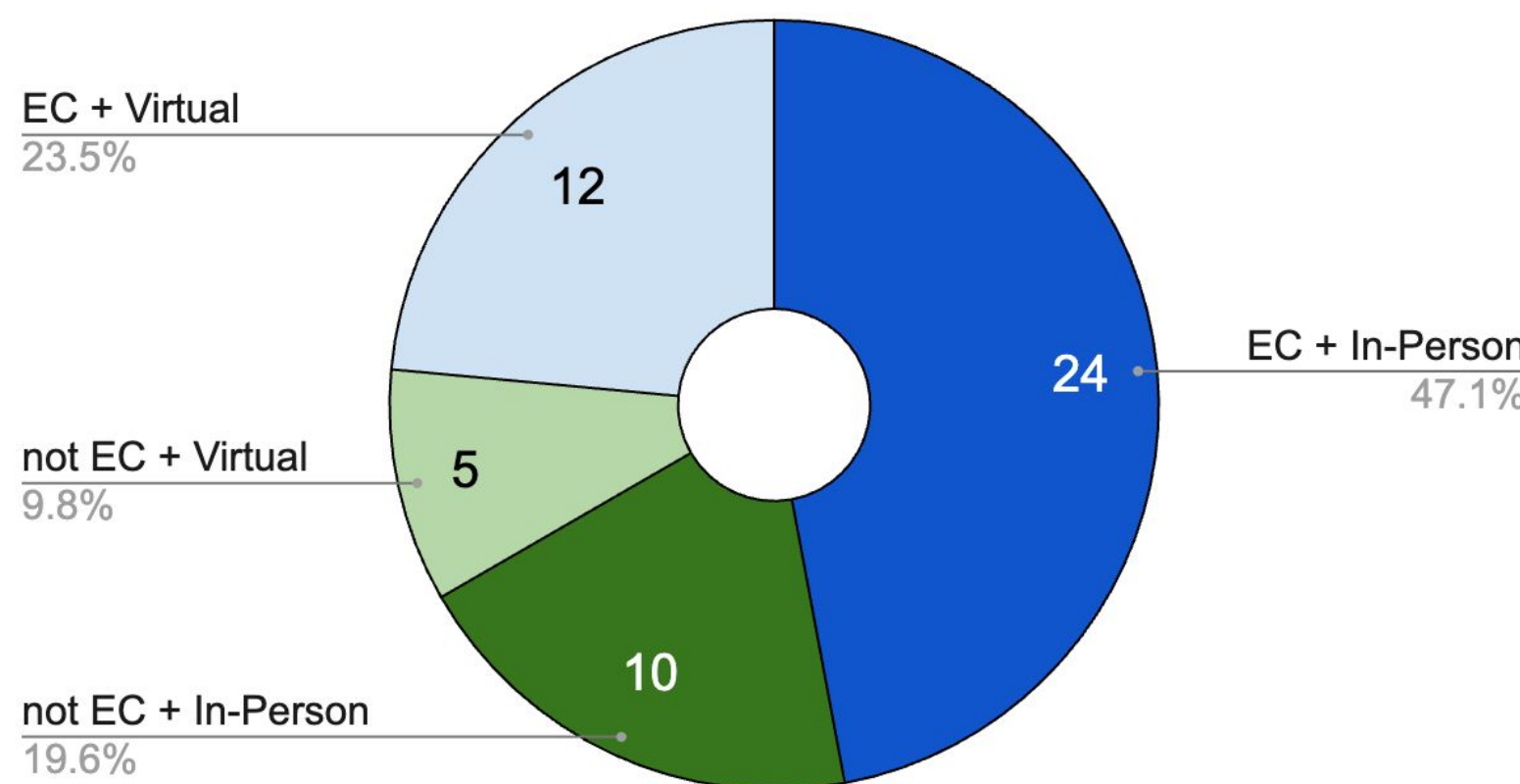
Hello! I noticed some fun trends in hobbies while putting together the buddy system matches! I wanted to do an impromptu poll to show off some of the common interests I found. I'll get us started and you can "vote" for any that you do by reaction, but also feel free to add your own hobbies via reactions and/or in the thread!

Bird watching 🐦 Hiking 🥾 Reading 📖 Anime 🌙 Dinosaurs/fossils/archeology 🦕 Running 🏃



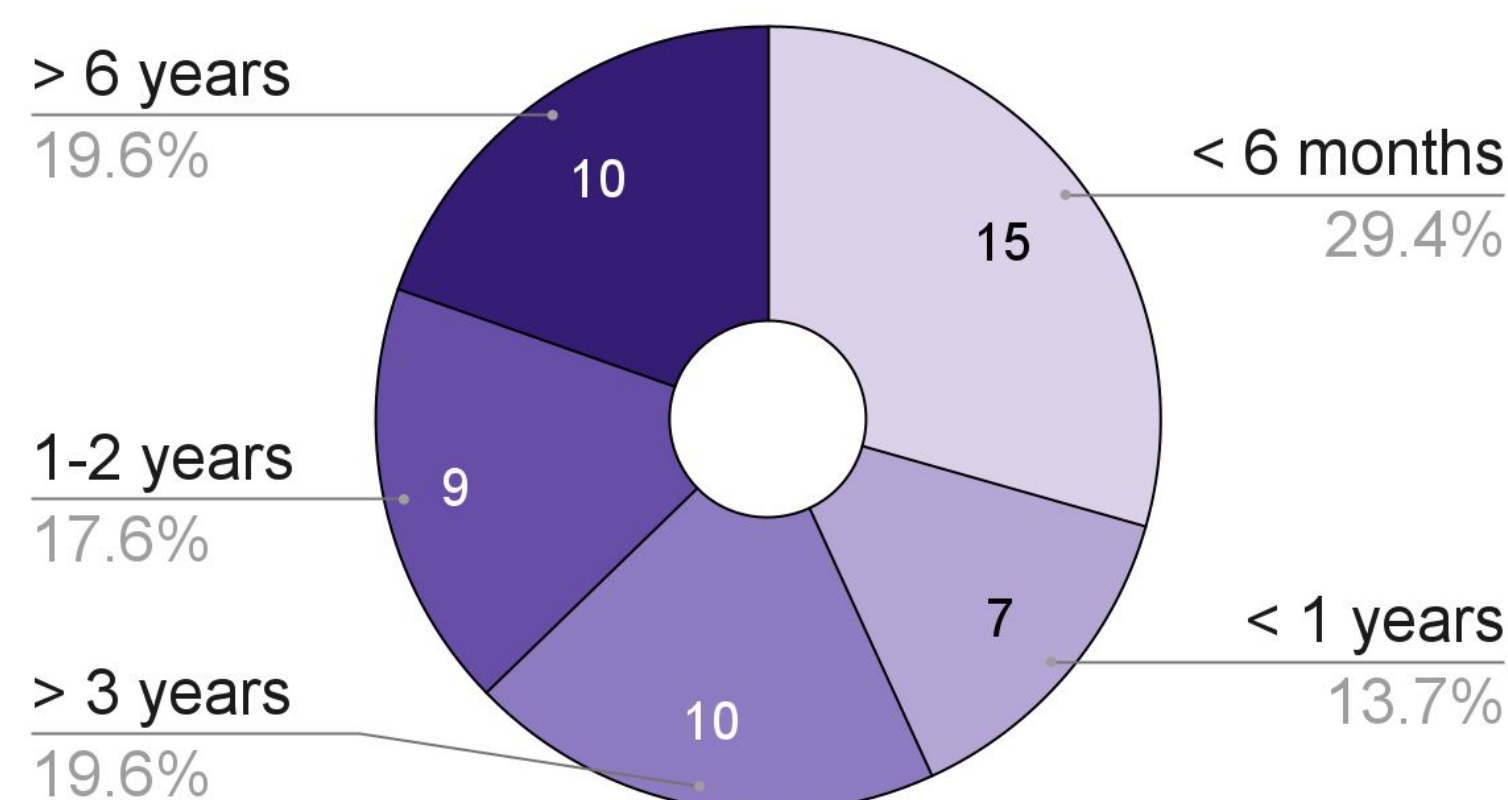
Participation:

Who's Participating? EC = Early Career (non-supervisors)



* from Winter 2025 program

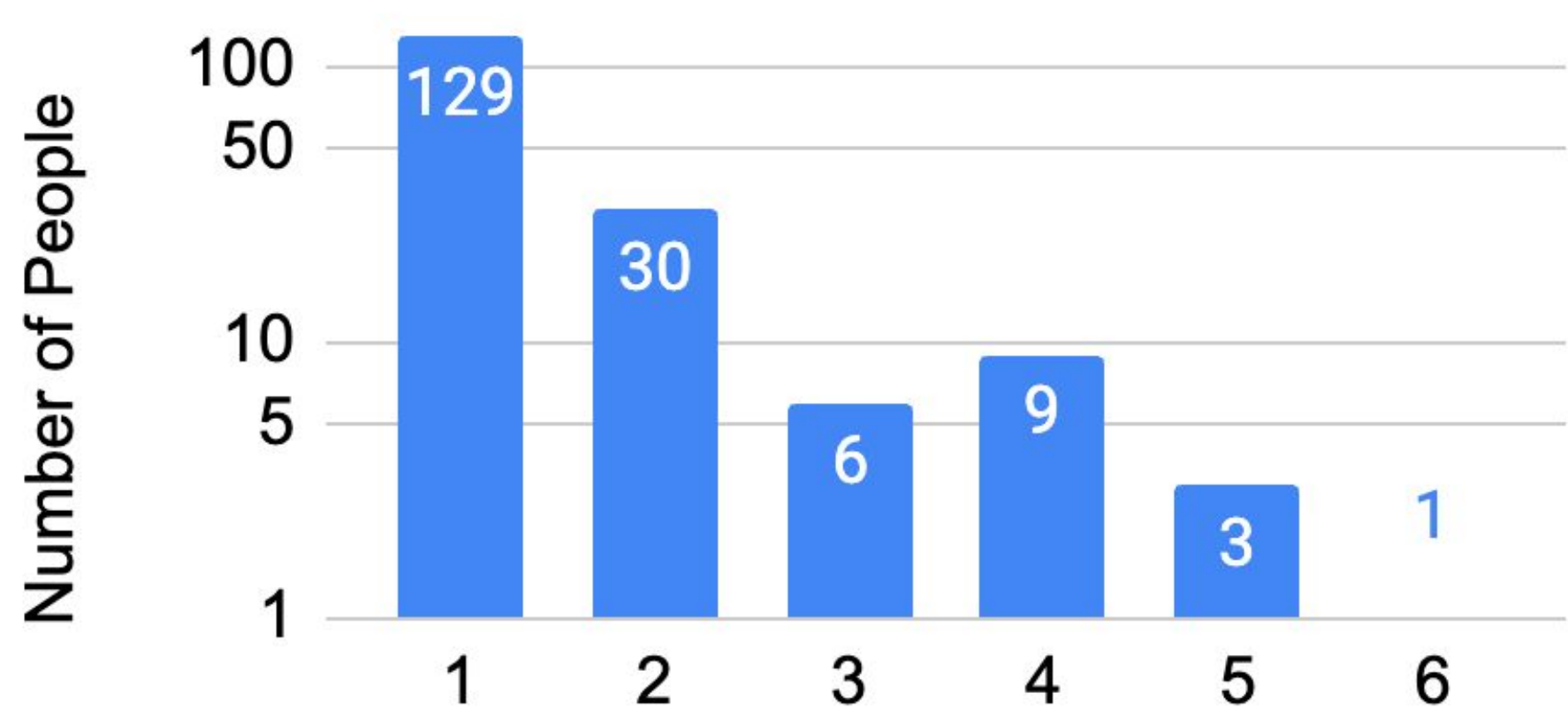
How long have you been on DUNE at time of participating?



* from Winter 2025 program

	Spring 2025	Winter 2025	Fall 2024	Spring 2024	Winter 2024	Fall 2023
< 6 months on DUNE	7	15	7	6	12	6
Virtual Attendee	25%	33%	59%	27%	25%	50%
Total # (% of attendees)	51 (12%)	51 (10%)	35 (9%)	37 (10%)	54 (8%)	35 (8%)

Number of Times People Have Participated



Number of Times Participating

178
people
over 6
meetings!